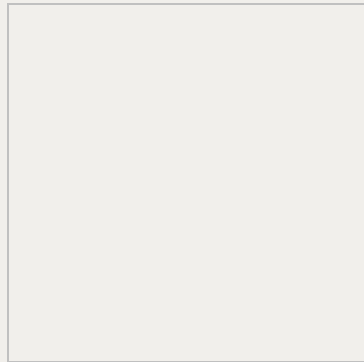


IN CONTEXT

The Great Purge, 1936–1938

During the 1930s, Stalin faced opposition as his policies failed to deliver prosperity. He began to fear a coup or even assassination. So began the “Great Purge,” in which he sought to eliminate his opponents and cow the population into compliance. The Ministry of Internal Affairs, NKVD, was given unprecedented powers. More than 1.5 million people were arrested, and hundreds of thousands of them executed. This reign of terror was not restricted to political dissidents, but extended to any prominent figures perceived to be critical of the Stalinist regime, including artists and composers.



LAVRENTIY PAVLOVICH BERIA, HEAD OF THE SOVIET SECRET
POLICE, THE NKVD

Dmitri Dmitriyevich Shostakovich was born in 1906 in St. Petersburg, a city whose changing names reflected the seismic changes in Russia during his lifetime; it was renamed Petrograd in 1914, and then became known as Leningrad in 1924, reverting to its original name in 1991. His father, of Polish descent, had